



INCLUDES

- ✓ Course framework
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- ✓ Sample exam questions

AP[®] English Literature and Composition

COURSE AND EXAM DESCRIPTION

Effective
Fall 2024

Sample Exam Questions

The sample exam questions that follow illustrate the relationship between the course framework and the AP English Literature and Composition Exam and serve as examples of the types of questions that appear on the exam. After the sample questions is an answer key and alignment table that shows how the questions relate to the course framework.

Section I: Multiple-Choice

Questions 1 through 10 refer to the following. Read the following carefully before you choose your answers.

*This passage is excerpted from Elizabeth Gaskell's novel *Ruth*, published in 1853.*

Line
5 There is an assize-town¹ in one of the eastern counties which was much distinguished by the Tudor sovereigns, and, in consequence of their favour and protection, attained a degree of importance that surprises the modern traveler.

A hundred years ago, its appearance was that of picturesque grandeur. The old houses, which were the temporary residences of such of the county-families as contented themselves with the gaieties of a provincial town, crowded the streets and gave them the irregular but noble appearance yet to be seen in the cities of Belgium. The sides of the streets had a quaint richness, from the effect of the gables, and the stacks of chimneys which cut against the blue sky above; while, if the eye fell lower down, the attention was arrested by all kinds of projections in the shape of balcony and oriel²; and it was amusing to see the infinite variety of windows that had been crammed into the walls long before Mr Pitt's³ days of taxation. The streets below suffered from all these projections and advanced stories above; they were dark, and ill-paved with large, round, jolting pebbles, and with no side-path protected by kerbstones; there were no lamp-posts for long winter nights; and no regard was paid to the wants of the middle class, who neither drove about in coaches of their own, nor were carried by their own men in their own sedans into the very halls of their friends. The professional men and their wives, the shopkeepers and their spouses, and all such people,

¹ a locus of judicial authority in Great Britain

² a type of window

³ William Pitt the Younger was a British prime minister.

walked about at considerable peril both night and day.

30 The broad unwieldy carriages hemmed them up against
the houses in the narrow streets. The inhospitable houses
projected their flights of steps almost into the
carriage-way, forcing pedestrians again into the danger
they had avoided for twenty or thirty paces. Then, at
35 night, the only light was derived from the glaring, flaring
oil-lamps hung above the doors of the more aristocratic
mansions; just allowing space for the passers-by to
become visible, before they again disappeared into the
darkness, where it was no uncommon thing for robbers
40 to be in waiting for their prey.

The traditions of those bygone times, even to the
smallest social particular, enable one to understand more
clearly the circumstances which contributed to the
formation of character. The daily life into which people
45 are born, and into which they are absorbed before they
are well aware, forms chains which only one in a hundred
has moral strength enough to despise, and to break when
the right time comes—when an inward necessity for
independent individual action arises, which is superior to
50 all outward conventionalities. Therefore it is well to know
what were the chains of daily domestic habit which were
the natural leading-strings of our forefathers before they
learnt to go alone.

The picturesqueness of those ancient streets has
55 departed now. The Astleys, the Dunstons, the
Waverhams—names of power in that district—go up
duly to London in the season, and have sold their
residences in the county-town fifty years ago, or more.
And when the county-town lost its attraction for the
60 Astleys, the Dunstons, the Waverhams, how could it be
supposed that the Domvilles, the Bextons, and the Wildes
would continue to go and winter there in their
second-rate houses, and with their increased
expenditure? So the grand old houses stood empty
65 awhile; and then speculators ventured to purchase, and to
turn the deserted mansions into many smaller dwellings,
fitted for professional men, or even (bend your ear lower,
lest the shade of Marmaduke, first Baron Waverham,
hear) into shops!

1. The function of the adjectives “picturesque” (line 7), “quaint” (line 12), and “amusing” (line 17) is primarily to
 - (A) introduce a sense of the town’s fanciful residential design
 - (B) inject comedy into the description of the town
 - (C) define the character of the town’s leading families
 - (D) call the supposed modernity of the town into question
2. The main purpose of the repetition of negative diction in lines 21-27 (“and with . . . friends”) is to emphasize the difference between the
 - (A) grand mansions and the small-town setting
 - (B) natural light and the artificial light
 - (C) aristocracy and the middle class
 - (D) welcoming homes and the dangerous streets
3. Which of the following statements best conveys the effect of the sentences in lines 30-34 (“The broad . . . paces”)?
 - (A) The imagery reinforces a sense of the vulnerability of the pedestrians.
 - (B) The candid tone removes blame from the owners of the houses.
 - (C) The exaggerated diction undercuts the danger mentioned in the previous sentence.
 - (D) The parallel structure emphasizes the unity among the townspeople.
4. In relation to the second paragraph (lines 6-40), the third paragraph (lines 41-53) represents a shift from
 - (A) the town’s history to the narrator’s own history
 - (B) a character’s perspective to an omniscient narrator’s perspective
 - (C) a primarily realistic account to a fantastical portrayal
 - (D) a detailed description to a philosophical commentary
5. The sentence in lines 44-50 (“The daily . . . conventionalities”) reveals that the narrator
 - (A) appreciates tradition
 - (B) deplores the town’s immorality
 - (C) admires self-determination
 - (D) condemns the aristocracy

6. Based on the second and third paragraphs (lines 6-53), which of the following can be reasonably inferred regarding the narrator's understanding of individual "character" (line 44)?
- (A) The inner lives of individuals develop independently of the political climate they are born into.
 - (B) The environment that individuals live and work in exerts a subtle but powerful influence on their inner lives.
 - (C) Moral virtue depends on rigorous discipline and careful instruction.
 - (D) Not even a rich inner life can compensate for wretched living conditions.
7. The metaphor of "chains" (lines 46 and 51) chiefly serves to emphasize the
- (A) power of one's circumstances
 - (B) pull of one's moral beliefs
 - (C) limitations of geography
 - (D) continuity of time
8. In lines 67-69 the statement in parentheses ("bend . . . hear") most clearly conveys a sense of
- (A) petty gossip
 - (B) respect for the dead
 - (C) awe of powerful men
 - (D) mock fear
9. The narrator's perspective throughout the passage might best be described as that of
- (A) an enthusiastic investigator
 - (B) a fantastical storyteller
 - (C) an interested commentator
 - (D) a former resident
10. In relation to the first sentence (lines 1-5), the remainder of the passage serves primarily to
- (A) explain why the assize-town is no longer a popular tourist destination
 - (B) explore the circumstances that account for the assize-town's great political and social prominence
 - (C) justify the claim that the visitor would be surprised by the history of the assize-town
 - (D) document the living conditions in the assize-town prior to the Tudor era

Questions 11 through 19 refer to the following. Read the following carefully before you choose your answers.

Marge Piercy's poem "To be of use" was published in 1973.

To be of use

- The people I love the best
jump into work head first
without dallying in the shallows
and swim off with sure strokes almost out of sight.
5 They seem to become natives of that element,
the black sleek heads of seals
bouncing like half-submerged balls.
- I love people who harness themselves, an ox to a heavy cart,
who pull like water buffalo, with massive patience,
10 who strain in the mud and the muck to move things forward,
who do what has to be done, again and again.
- I want to be with people who submerge
in the task, who go into the fields to harvest
and work in a row and pass the bags along,
15 who are not parlor generals and field deserters
but move in a common rhythm
when the food must come in or the fire be put out.
- The work of the world is common as mud.
Botched, it smears the hands, crumbles to dust.
20 But the thing worth doing well done
has a shape that satisfies, clean and evident.
Greek amphoras for wine or oil,
Hopi vases that held corn, are put in museums
but you know they were made to be used.
25 The pitcher cries for water to carry
and a person for work that is real.

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11. The poem as a whole is best understood as a
- (A) plea for work to be less burdensome
 - (B) vindication of the humanity of workers
 - (C) celebration of earnest work and workers
 - (D) defense of unusual types of work and workers
12. In context, "dallying in the shallows" (line 3) most nearly means
- (A) waiting for worthwhile work
 - (B) lingering over satisfying labor
 - (C) pretending to complete a job
 - (D) hesitating to perform a task

13. In line 5, “that element” refers to both
- (A) water and work
 - (B) love and labor
 - (C) mud and muck
 - (D) wind and tides
14. Which best describes the difference in the way the “people” (lines 1 and 8) are characterized in stanza one versus stanza two?
- (A) Supple grace versus undisciplined power
 - (B) Eager activity versus plodding exertion
 - (C) Measured patience versus hopeless resignation
 - (D) Innate enthusiasm versus thoughtful neutrality
15. In the poem, the term “parlor generals” (line 15) most probably refers to individuals who
- (A) behave with unrelenting valor on the battlefield
 - (B) have retired from illustrious careers, only to be forgotten
 - (C) have performed deeds because they sought public praise
 - (D) hold forth as experts on work they have never accomplished
16. The word “submerge” (line 12) most clearly echoes which earlier line from the poem?
- (A) Line 2 (“jump . . . first”)
 - (B) Line 8 (“I love . . . cart”)
 - (C) Line 9 (“who pull . . . patience”)
 - (D) Line 10 (“who strain . . . forward”)
17. One effect of the shift in the speaker’s focus in the third stanza is to
- (A) introduce the idea that dedication to a task is a quality valued by most people
 - (B) argue that it is better to be a follower than a leader
 - (C) emphasize the value that the speaker puts on the act of collaboration
 - (D) lament the speaker’s own tendency toward thought instead of action
18. In lines 20–21, the speaker suggests which of the following about work?
- (A) It can have aesthetic value.
 - (B) It may bind people together.
 - (C) It is rarely well done.
 - (D) It should express the workers’ feelings.

19. The speaker mentions “wine or oil” (line 22) and “corn” (line 23) to highlight the
- (A) useful commodities supplied by work
 - (B) functional nature of some venerated objects
 - (C) enigmatic purpose of certain historical artifacts
 - (D) artistry implicit in mundane items

Section II: Free-Response

The following are examples of the kinds of free-response questions found on the exam.

Poetry Analysis (Free-Response Question 1 on the AP Exam)

In Ralph Waldo Emerson's poem, "Terminus," published in 1867, the speaker reflects on the process of growing older. Read the poem carefully. Then, in a well-written essay, analyze how Emerson uses literary elements and techniques to convey the speaker's complex perspective on aging.

In your response you should do the following:

- Respond to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation.
- Select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning.
- Explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning.
- Use appropriate grammar and punctuation in communicating your argument.

Terminus¹

It is time to be old,
To take in sail:—
The god of bounds,
Who sets to seas a shore,
5 Came to me in his fatal rounds,
And said: "No more!
No farther shoot
Thy broad ambitious branches, and thy root.
Fancy departs: no more invent;
10 Contract thy firmament
To compass of a tent.
There's not enough for this and that,
Make thy option which of two;
Economize the failing river,
15 Not the less revere the Giver,
Leave the many and hold the few.
Timely wise accept the terms,
Soften the fall with wary foot;
A little while
20 Still plan and smile,
And,—fault of novel germs,—
Mature the unfallen fruit.
Curse, if thou wilt, thy sires,
Bad husbands of their fires,

¹the Roman god of boundaries

25 Who, when they gave thee breath,
Failed to bequeath
The needful sinew stark as once,
The Baresark² marrow to thy bones,
But left a legacy of ebbing veins,
30 Inconstant heat and nerveless reins,—
Amid the Muses, left thee deaf and dumb,
Amid the gladiators,³ halt and numb.”
As the bird trims⁴ her to the gale,
I trim myself to the storm of time,
35 I man the rudder, reef the sail,
Obey the voice at eve obeyed at prime:
“Lowly faithful, banish fear,
Right onward drive unharmed;
The port, well worth the cruise, is near,
40 And every wave is charmed.”

²A Baresark was an ancient Scandinavian warrior who fought without armor, was frenzied in battle, and was thought to be invulnerable.

³In ancient Rome, gladiators fought to the death for the public's entertainment.

⁴adjusts

Prose Fiction Analysis (Free-Response Question 2 on the AP Exam)

This [passage](#) is excerpted from Jamaica Kincaid's novel *Lucy*, published in 1990 and can be found on the AP English Literature and Composition Classroom Resources Page. In this passage, the narrator describes the beginning of a new phase in her life. Read the passage carefully. Then, in a well-written essay, analyze how Kincaid uses literary elements and techniques to portray the complexity of the narrator's new situation.

In your response you should do the following:

- Respond to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation.
- Select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning.
- Explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning.
- Use appropriate grammar and punctuation in communicating your argument.

Literary Argument (Free-Response Question 3 on the AP Exam)

In many works of literature, characters who have been away from home return and find that they no longer have the same feelings about home as they once did. As novelist James Agee writes in *A Death In the Family*, “You can go home, it’s good to go home, but you never really get all the way home again in your life.”

Either from your own reading or from the list below, choose a work of fiction in which a character’s return home is problematic: “home” is not what it once was perceived to be. Then, in a well-written essay, analyze how the character’s response to his or her “home” contributes to an interpretation of the work as a whole. Do not merely summarize the plot.

In your response you should do the following:

- Respond to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation.
- Provide evidence to support your line of reasoning.
- Explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning.
- Use appropriate grammar and punctuation in communicating your argument.

- | | |
|---|---|
| • <i>The Age of Innocence</i> | • <i>The Mill on the Floss</i> |
| • <i>Americanah</i> | • <i>Mrs. Dalloway</i> |
| • <i>The Bell Jar</i> | • <i>My Ántonia</i> |
| • <i>The Bonesetter’s Daughter</i> | • <i>The Namesake</i> |
| • <i>Breath, Eyes, Memory</i> | • <i>Native Son</i> |
| • <i>Brighton Beach Memoirs</i> | • <i>Paradise Lost</i> |
| • <i>Ceremony</i> | • <i>The Piano Lesson</i> |
| • <i>Cold Mountain</i> | • <i>The Poisonwood Bible</i> |
| • <i>Death of a Salesman</i> | • <i>Pudd’nhead Wilson</i> |
| • <i>Exit West</i> | • <i>Pygmalion</i> |
| • <i>Great Expectations</i> | • <i>Quicksand</i> |
| • <i>Gulliver’s Travels</i> | • <i>The Return of the Native</i> |
| • <i>Home</i> | • <i>The Scarlet Letter</i> |
| • <i>Homegoing</i> | • <i>Song of Solomon</i> |
| • <i>The Hummingbird’s Daughter</i> | • <i>Sons and Other Flammable Objects</i> |
| • <i>Kindred</i> | • <i>The Sound and the Fury</i> |
| • <i>The Kite Runner</i> | • <i>The Tempest</i> |
| • <i>The Lonely Londoners</i> | • <i>Their Eyes Were Watching God</i> |
| • <i>The Mambo Kings Play Songs of Love</i> | • <i>Where the Dead Sit Talking</i> |
| • <i>Mansfield Park</i> | • <i>Wuthering Heights</i> |

Answer Key and Question Alignment to Course Framework

Multiple-Choice Question	Answer	Skill	Essential Knowledge
1	A	5.B	FIG-1.M
2	C	5.B	FIG-1.C
3	A	5.D	FIG-1.Q
4	D	3.D	STR-1.J
5	C	4.C	NAR-1.R
6	B	4.C	NAR-1.R
7	A	6.B	FIG-1.K
8	D	4.C	NAR-1.Q
9	C	4.A	NAR-1.B
10	C	3.C	STR-1.F
11	C	7.B	LAN-1.D
12	D	6.B	FIG-1.K
13	A	5.B	FIG-1.B
14	B	4.C	NAR-1.X
15	D	6.B	FIG-1.K
16	A	3.C	STR-1.AC
17	C	3.D	STR-1.J
18	A	5.D	FIG-1.O
19	B	4.C	NAR-1.N

Free-Response Question	Question Type	Skill
1	Poetry Analysis	4.C, 7.A, 7.B, 7.C, 7.D, 7.E
2	Prose Fiction Analysis	1.A, 7.A, 7.B, 7.C, 7.D, 7.E
3	Literary Argument	1.E, 2.C, 7.A, 7.B, 7.C, 7.D, 7.E

The scoring information for the questions within this course and exam description, along with further exam resources, can be found on the [AP English Literature and Composition Exam Page](#) on AP Central.



Scoring Guidelines

Question 1: Poetry Analysis

6 points

In Ralph Waldo Emerson's poem, "Terminus," published in 1867, the speaker reflects on the process of growing older. Read the poem carefully. Then, in a well-written essay, analyze how Emerson uses literary elements and techniques to convey the speaker's complex perspective on aging.

In your response you should do the following:

- Respond to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation.
- Select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning.
- Explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning.
- Use appropriate grammar and punctuation in communicating your argument.

Terminus¹

It is time to be old,
To take in sail:—
The god of bounds,
Who sets to seas a shore,
5 Came to me in his fatal rounds,
And said: "No more!
No farther shoot
Thy broad ambitious branches, and thy root.
Fancy departs: no more invent;
10 Contract thy firmament
To compass of a tent.

¹the Roman god of boundaries

There's not enough for this and that,
 Make thy option which of two;
 Economize the failing river,
 15 Not the less revere the Giver,
 Leave the many and hold the few.
 Timely wise accept the terms,
 Soften the fall with wary foot;
 A little while
 20 Still plan and smile,
 And,—fault of novel germs,—
 Mature the unfallen fruit.
 Curse, if thou wilt, thy sires,
 Bad husbands of their fires,
 25 Who, when they gave thee breath,
 Failed to bequeath
 The needful sinew stark as once,
 The Baresark² marrow to thy bones,
 But left a legacy of ebbing veins,
 30 Inconstant heat and nerveless reins,—
 Amid the Muses, left thee deaf and dumb,
 Amid the gladiators,³ halt and numb.”
 As the bird trims⁴ her to the gale,
 I trim myself to the storm of time,
 35 I man the rudder, reef the sail,
 Obey the voice at eve obeyed at prime:
 “Lowly faithful, banish fear,
 Right onward drive unharmed;
 The port, well worth the cruise, is near,
 40 And every wave is charmed.”

²A Baresark was an ancient Scandinavian warrior who fought without armor, was frenzied in battle, and was thought to be invulnerable.

³In ancient Rome, gladiators fought to the death for the public's entertainment.

⁴adjusts

Scoring Guidelines for Question 1: Poetry Analysis		6 points
Reporting	Scoring Criteria	
Row A Thesis (0-1 points) 7.B	0 points For any of the following: - There is no defensible thesis. - The intended thesis only restates the prompt. - The intended thesis provides a summary of the issue with no apparent or coherent claim. - There is a thesis, but it does not respond to the prompt.	1 point Responds to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation of the poem.
	Decision Rules and Scoring Notes	
	Responses that do not earn this point: - Only restate the prompt. - Make a generalized comment about the poem that doesn't respond to the prompt. - Describe the poem or features of the poem rather than making a claim that requires a defense.	Responses that earn this point: Provide a defensible interpretation of the speaker's complex perspective on aging.
	Examples that do not earn this point: Restate the prompt "Emerson directly addresses this process through different poetic elements and techniques that convey complexity of the subject." "In the poem 'Terminus,' by Ralph Waldo Emerson, the speaker has a complex perspective on the process of aging." Do not relate to the prompt "Death comes to us all and it is that fact which Emerson addresses in his Poem 'Terminus.'" Describe the poem or features of the poem "Throughout the poem, Emerson expresses growing old as if he were sailing. He spent his young life in port, and as he got older and older, he readies his ship and sailed on the ocean blue. The ocean blue represented growing older for Emerson, each breeze and each wave bringing him closer to the 'port well worth the cruise.'"	Examples that earn this point: Provide a defensible interpretation "While many people view aging as a progression toward the pain and loss of death, the speaker in Emerson's poem 'Terminus' views aging as 'well worth the cruise' as death approaches and the ship of life comes home to port." "The poem describes aging as a lengthy, and a rather damning process. However, aging and death should not be feared, the speaker views it as returning home." "Throughout his poem 'Terminus' Emerson conveys his perspective that aging is a time to settle down through an extended metaphor, similes, metaphors, diction, imagery and personification. Emerson explores the idea that aging is a calm time at the end of a chaotic life."
	Additional Notes: - The thesis may be more than one sentence, provided the sentences are in close proximity. - The thesis may be anywhere within the response. - For a thesis to be defensible, the poem must include at least minimal evidence that <i>could</i> be used to support that thesis; however, the student need not cite that evidence to earn the thesis point. - The thesis <i>may</i> establish a line of reasoning that structures the essay, but it needn't do so to earn the thesis point. - A thesis that meets the criteria can be awarded the point whether or not the rest of the response successfully supports that line of reasoning.	

Reporting Category	Scoring Criteria				
Row B Evidence AND Commentary (0-4 points) 7.A 7.C 7.D 7.E	0 points Simply restates thesis (if present), repeats provided information, or offers information irrelevant to the prompt.	1 point EVIDENCE: Provides evidence that is mostly general. AND COMMENTARY: Summarizes the evidence but does not explain how the evidence supports the student's argument.	2 points EVIDENCE: Provides some specific, relevant evidence. AND COMMENTARY: Explains how some of the evidence relates to the student's argument, but no line of reasoning is established, or the line of reasoning is faulty.	3 points EVIDENCE: Provides specific evidence to support all claims in a line of reasoning. AND COMMENTARY: Explains how some of the evidence supports a line of reasoning. AND Explains how at least one literary element or technique in the poem contributes to its meaning.	4 points EVIDENCE: Provides specific evidence to support all claims in a line of reasoning. AND COMMENTARY: Consistently explains how the evidence supports a line of reasoning. AND Explains how multiple literary elements or techniques in the poem contribute to its meaning.
Decision Rules and Scoring Notes					
	Typical responses that earn 0 points: - Are incoherent or do not address the prompt. - May be just opinion with no textual references or references that are irrelevant.	Typical responses that earn 1 point: - Tend to focus on summary or description of a poem rather than specific details or techniques. - Mention literary elements, devices, or techniques with little or no explanation.	Typical responses that earn 2 points: - Consist of a mix of specific evidence and broad generalities. - May contain some simplistic, inaccurate, or repetitive explanations that don't strengthen the argument. - May make one point well but either do not make multiple supporting claims or do not adequately support more than one claim. - Do not explain the connections or progression between the student's claims, so a line of reasoning is not clearly established.	Typical responses that earn 3 points: - Uniformly offer evidence to support claims. - Focus on the importance of specific words and details from the poem to build an interpretation. - Organize an argument as a line of reasoning composed of multiple supporting claims. - Commentary may fail to integrate some evidence or fail to support a key claim.	Typical responses that earn 4 points: - Uniformly offer evidence to support claims. - Focus on the importance of specific words and details from the poem to build an interpretation. - Organize and support an argument as a line of reasoning composed of multiple supporting claims, each with adequate evidence that is clearly explained. - Explain how the writer's use of multiple literary techniques contributes to the student's interpretation of the poem.
Additional Notes: - Writing that suffers from grammatical and/or mechanical errors that interfere with communication cannot earn the fourth point in this row. - To earn the fourth point in this row, the response may observe multiple instances of the same literary element or technique if each instance further contributes to the meaning of the poem.					

Reporting Category	Scoring Criteria	
Row C Sophistication (0-1 points) 7.C 7.D 7.E	0 points Does not meet the criteria for one point.	1 point Demonstrates sophistication of thought and/or develops a complex literary argument.
	Decision Rules and Scoring Notes	
	Responses that do not earn this point: • Attempt to contextualize their interpretation, but such attempts consist predominantly of sweeping generalizations (<i>"Human experiences always include..." OR "In a world where..." OR "Since the beginning of time..."</i>). • Only hint at or suggest other possible interpretations (<i>"While another reader may see..." OR "Though the poem could be said to..."</i>). • Make a single statement about how an interpretation of the poem comments on something thematic without consistently maintaining that thematic interpretation. • Oversimplify complexities in the poem. • Use complicated or complex sentences or language that is ineffective because it does not enhance the student's argument.	Responses that earn this point may demonstrate a sophistication of thought or develop a complex literary argument by doing any of the following: 1. Identifying and exploring complexities or tensions within the poem. 2. Illuminating the student's interpretation by situating it within a broader context. 3. Accounting for alternative interpretations of the poem. 4. Employing a style that is consistently vivid and persuasive.
	Additional Notes: • This point should be awarded only if the sophistication of thought or complex understanding is part of the student's argument, not merely a phrase or reference.	

Question 2: Prose Fiction Analysis

6 points

This **passage** is excerpted from Jamaica Kincaid’s novel *Lucy*, published in 1990 and can be found on the AP English Literature and Composition Classroom Resources Page. In this passage, the narrator describes the beginning of a new phase in her life. Read the passage carefully. Then, in a well-written essay, analyze how Kincaid uses literary elements and techniques to portray the complexity of the narrator’s new situation.

In your response you should do the following:

- Respond to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation.
- Select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning.
- Explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning.
- Use appropriate grammar and punctuation in communicating your argument.

Scoring Guidelines for Question 2: Prose Fiction Analysis			6 points
Reporting Category	Scoring Criteria		
Row A Thesis (0-1 points) 7.B	0 points For any of the following: - There is no defensible thesis. - The intended thesis only restates the prompt. - The intended thesis provides a summary of the issue with no apparent or coherent claim. - There is a thesis, but it does not respond to the prompt.		1 point Responds to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation of the passage.
	Decision Rules and Scoring Notes		
	Responses that do not earn this point: - Only restate the prompt. - Make a generalized comment about the passage that doesn't respond to the prompt. - Describe the passage or features of the passage rather than making a claim that requires a defense.		Responses that earn this point: Provide a defensible interpretation of Kincaid's portrayal of the complexity of the narrator's new situation.
	Examples that do not earn this point: Restate the prompt "Kincaid's narrator makes adept use of literary devices when discuss the complexity of her new situation." Do not respond to the prompt but make a generalized comment "The narrator in Kincaid's novel demonstrates the importance of home and belonging." Describe the passage or features of the passage "Kincaid uses very detailed description of places and contrasting of those places to develop the narrator's experience."		Examples that earn this point: Provide a defensible interpretation "Kincaid, through the use of imagery, em dashes, and repetition revealed her complex dilemma of wanting to go home or staying in a newer environment." "In 1990, Jamaica Kincaid's novel <u>Lucy</u>, depicts this life change and the narrator's feelings. Kincaid uses repetition of phrases, diction that illicit pathos, and a mood of uncertainty and questioning to show how the narrator feels unsure and worried about moving from her hometown and how, despite a chance to restart her life, she still wants to go back." "The narrator is surprised to experience homesickness in a new place where she thought she would find comfort."
	Additional Notes: - The thesis may be more than one sentence, provided the sentences are in close proximity. - The thesis may be anywhere within the response. - For a thesis to be defensible, the passage must include at least minimal evidence that could be used to support that thesis; however, the student need not cite that evidence to earn the thesis point. - The thesis <i>may</i> establish a line of reasoning that structures the essay, but it needn't do so to earn the thesis point. - A thesis that meets the criteria can be awarded the point whether or not the rest of the response successfully supports that line of reasoning.		

Reporting Category	Scoring Criteria				
Row B Evidence AND Commentary (0-4 points) 7.A 7.C 7.D 7.E	0 points Simply restates thesis (if present), repeats provided information, or offers information irrelevant to the prompt.	1 point EVIDENCE: Provides evidence that is mostly general. AND COMMENTARY: Summarizes the evidence but does not explain how the evidence supports the student's argument.	2 points EVIDENCE: Provides some specific, relevant evidence. AND COMMENTARY: Explains how some of the evidence relates to the student's argument, but no line of reasoning is established, or the line of reasoning is faulty.	3 points EVIDENCE: Provides specific evidence to support all claims in a line of reasoning. AND COMMENTARY: Explains how some of the evidence supports a line of reasoning. AND Explains how at least one literary element or technique in the passage contributes to its meaning.	4 points EVIDENCE: Provides specific evidence to support all claims in a line of reasoning. AND COMMENTARY: Consistently explains how the evidence supports a line of reasoning. AND Explains how multiple literary elements or techniques in the passage contribute to its meaning.
	Decision Rules and Scoring Notes				
	Typical responses that earn 0 points: - Are incoherent or do not address the prompt. - May be just opinion with no textual references or references that are irrelevant.	Typical responses that earn 1 point: - Tend to focus on overarching narrative developments or description of a passage rather than specific details or techniques. - Mention literary elements, devices, or techniques with little or no explanation.	Typical responses that earn 2 points: - Consist of a mix of specific evidence and broad generalities. - May contain some simplistic, inaccurate, or repetitive explanations that don't strengthen the argument. - May make one point well but either do not make multiple supporting claims or do not adequately support more than one claim. - Do not explain the connections or progression between the student's claims, so a line of reasoning is not clearly established.	Typical responses that earn 3 points: - Uniformly offer evidence to support claims. - Focus on the importance of specific words and details from the passage to build an interpretation. - Organize an argument as a line of reasoning composed of multiple supporting claims. - Commentary may fail to integrate some evidence or fail to support a key claim.	Typical responses that earn 4 points: - Uniformly offer evidence to support claims. - Focus on the importance of specific words and details from the passage to build an interpretation. - Organize and support an argument as a line of reasoning composed of multiple supporting claims, each with adequate evidence that is clearly explained. - Explain how the writer's use of multiple literary techniques contributes to the student's interpretation of the passage.
Additional Notes: - Writing that suffers from grammatical and/or mechanical errors that interfere with communication cannot earn the fourth point in this row. - To earn the fourth point in this row, the response may observe multiple instances of the same literary element or technique if each instance further contributes to the meaning of the passage.					

Reporting Category	Scoring Criteria	
Row C Sophistication (0-1 points) 7.C 7.D 7.E	0 points Does not meet the criteria for one point.	1 point Demonstrates sophistication of thought and/or develops a complex literary argument.
	Decision Rules and Scoring Notes	
	Responses that do not earn this point: - Attempt to contextualize their interpretation, but such attempts consist predominantly of sweeping generalizations (“<i>Human experiences always include...</i>” OR “<i>In a world where...</i>” OR “<i>Since the beginning of time...</i>”). - Only hint at or suggest other possible interpretations (“<i>While another reader may see...</i>” OR “<i>Though the passage could be said to...</i>”). - Make a single statement about how an interpretation of the passage comments on something thematic without consistently maintaining that thematic interpretation. - Oversimplify complexities in the passage. - Use complicated or complex sentences or language that is ineffective because it does not enhance the student’s argument.	Responses that earn this point may demonstrate a sophistication of thought or develop a complex literary argument by doing any of the following: - Identifying and exploring complexities or tensions within the passage. - Illuminating the student’s interpretation by situating it within a broader context. - Accounting for alternative interpretations of the passage. - Employing a style that is consistently vivid and persuasive.
	Additional Notes: This point should be awarded only if the sophistication of thought or complex understanding is part of the student’s argument, not merely a phrase or reference.	

Question 3: Literary Argument

6 points

In many works of literature, characters who have been away from home return and find that they no longer have the same feelings about home as they once did. As novelist James Agee writes in *A Death in the Family*, “You can go home, it’s good to go home, but you never really get all the way home again in your life.”

Either from your own reading or from the list below, choose a work of fiction in which a character’s return home is problematic: “home” is not what it once was perceived to be. Then, in a well-written essay, analyze how the character’s response to his or her “home” contributes to an interpretation of the work as a whole. Do not merely summarize the plot.

In your response, you should do the following:

- Respond to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation.
- Provide evidence to support your line of reasoning.
- Explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning.
- Use appropriate grammar and punctuation in communicating your argument.

- *The Age of Innocence*
- *Americanah*
- *The Bell Jar*
- *The Bonesetter’s Daughter*
- *Breath, Eyes, Memory*
- *Brighton Beach Memoirs*
- *Ceremony*
- *Cold Mountain*
- *Death of a Salesman*
- *Exit West*
- *Great Expectations*
- *Gulliver’s Travels*
- *Home*
- *Homegoing*
- *The Hummingbird’s Daughter*
- *Kindred*
- *The Kite Runner*
- *The Lonely Londoners*
- *The Mambo Kings Play Songs of Love*
- *Mansfield Park*

- *The Mill on the Floss*
- *Mrs. Dalloway*
- *My Ántonia*
- *The Namesake*
- *Native Son*
- *Paradise Lost*
- *The Piano Lesson*
- *The Poisonwood Bible*
- *Pudd’nhead Wilson*
- *Pygmalion*
- *Quicksand*
- *The Return of the Native*
- *The Scarlet Letter*
- *Song of Solomon*
- *Sons and Other Flammable Objects*
- *The Sound and the Fury*
- *The Tempest*
- *Their Eyes Were Watching God*
- *Where the Dead Sit Talking*
- *Wuthering Heights*

Scoring Guidelines for Question 3: Literary Argument

6 points

Reporting Category	Scoring Criteria	
Row A Thesis (0-1 points) 7.B	0 points For any of the following: - There is no defensible thesis. - The intended thesis only restates the prompt. - The intended thesis provides a summary of the issue with no apparent or coherent thesis. - There is a thesis, but it does not respond to the prompt.	1 point Responds to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible interpretation of the selected work.
	Decision Rules and Scoring Notes	
	Responses that do not earn this point: - Only restate the prompt. - Make a generalized comment about the selected work that doesn't respond to the prompt.	Responses that earn this point: - Provide a defensible interpretation of the character's response to his or her "home" in the selected work. OR - Make a claim about how the character's response to his or her "home" contributes to the meaning of the work as a whole.
	Examples that do not earn this point: Restate the prompt "Things are always changing—this includes places and people. A character who leaves their home can never really return to it as it and they are always changing. What matters is how they react to it when they do return." Do not respond to the prompt but make a generalized comment about the selected work "In <i>Anthem</i>, Equality leaves what he has known as his home and never looks back." "Leaving home is never easy. Coming back home is even harder. Many characters face these problems in a number of books."	Examples that earn this point: Provides a defensible interpretation "While Shukov feels alienated by his 'home,' Tsezar relies on his as a source of physical and intellectual strength." "In Jean-Paul Sartre's <i>The Flies</i>, the main protagonist, Orestes, experiences a disillusionment with the idea of home when he makes his return to the city of Argos. Orestes' anger and frustration with the state of Argos upon his return informs every decision he makes for the duration of the play, and it highlights Sartre's greater point: allowing one's decisions to be influenced by external establishments without independent determination is the ultimate disservice to oneself." "Ultimately, Santiago from Coelho's <i>The Alchemist</i> is disappointed when he comes home to find that things aren't the same as they once were year prior. Santiago's disappointment helps Coelho display his message: Focus on the present and look forward, never back."
	Additional Notes: - The thesis may be more than one sentence, provided the sentences are in close proximity. - The thesis may be anywhere within the response. - A thesis that offers a defensible claim about a character's response to his or her "home" in the selected work may earn the point; any reasonable student interpretation of "home" is acceptable. - For a thesis to be defensible, the selected work must include at least minimal evidence that <i>could</i> be used to support that thesis; however, the student need not cite that evidence to earn the thesis point. - The thesis <i>may</i> establish a line of reasoning that structures the essay, but it needn't do so to earn the thesis point. - A thesis that meets the criteria can be awarded the point whether or not the rest of the response successfully supports that line of reasoning.	

Reporting Category	Scoring Criteria				
Row B Evidence AND Commentary (0-4 points) 7.A 7.C 7.D 7.E	0 points Simply restates thesis (if present), repeats provided information, or offers information irrelevant to the prompt.	1 point EVIDENCE: Provides evidence that is mostly general. AND COMMENTARY: Summarizes the evidence but does not explain how the evidence supports the argument.	2 points EVIDENCE: Provides some specific, relevant evidence. AND COMMENTARY: Explains how some of the evidence relates to the student's argument, but no line of reasoning is established, or the line of reasoning is faulty.	3 points EVIDENCE: Provides specific evidence to support all claims in a line of reasoning. AND COMMENTARY: Explains how some of the evidence supports a line of reasoning.	4 points EVIDENCE: Provides specific evidence to support all claims in a line of reasoning. AND COMMENTARY: Consistently explains how the evidence supports a line of reasoning.
	Decision Rules and Scoring Notes				
	Typical responses that earn 0 points: - Are incoherent or do not address the prompt. - May be just opinion with no textual references or references that are irrelevant.	Typical responses that earn 1 point: Tend to focus on overarching narrative developments or description of a selected work rather than specific details.	Typical responses that earn 2 points: - Consist of a mix of specific evidence and broad generalities. - May contain some simplistic, inaccurate, or repetitive explanations that don't strengthen the argument. - May make one point well but either do not make multiple supporting claims or do not adequately support more than one claim. - Do not explain the connections or progression between the student's claims, so a line of reasoning is not clearly established.	Typical responses that earn 3 points: - Uniformly offer evidence to support claims. - Focus on the importance of specific details from the selected work to build an interpretation. - Organize an argument as a line of reasoning composed of multiple supporting claims. - Commentary may fail to integrate some evidence or fail to support a key claim.	Typical responses that earn 4 points: - Uniformly offer evidence to support claims. - Focus on the importance of specific details from the selected works to build an interpretation. - Organize and support an argument as a line of reasoning composed of multiple supporting claims, each with adequate evidence that is clearly explained.
Additional Notes: - Writing that suffers from grammatical and/or mechanical errors that interfere with communication cannot earn the fourth point in this row. - To earn the fourth point in this row, the response must address the interpretation of the selected work as a whole.					

Reporting Category	Scoring Criteria	
Row C Sophistication (0-1 points) 7.C 7.D 7.E	0 points Does not meet the criteria for one point.	1 point Demonstrates sophistication of thought and/or develops a complex literary argument.
	Decision Rules and Scoring Notes	
	Responses that do not earn this point: - Attempt to contextualize their interpretation, but such attempts consist predominantly of sweeping generalizations (<i>"Human experiences always include..." OR "In a world where..." OR "Since the beginning of time..."</i>). - Only hint at or suggest other possible interpretations (<i>"While another reader may see..." OR "Though the text could be said to..."</i>). - Oversimplify complexities of the topic and/or the selected work. - Use complicated or complex sentences or language that is ineffective because it does not enhance the student's argument.	Responses that earn this point may demonstrate a sophistication of thought or develop a complex literary argument by doing any of the following: - Identifying and exploring complexities or tensions within the selected work. - Illuminating the student's interpretation by situating it within a broader context. - Accounting for alternative interpretations of the text. - Employing a style that is consistently vivid and persuasive.
	Additional Notes: This point should be awarded only if the sophistication of thought or complex understanding is part of the student's argument, not merely a phrase or reference.	